



Young adults / Early adulthood



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Markers of adulthood

- Generally, early adulthood is considered to be age 20-40
- What do you think are the markers of adulthood?
- Emerging adulthood
- Age graded influences, history graded influences
- Feeling off-time

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Physical development

- End of maturation
- Peak period of physical function in the first part of early adulthood
- Decline has begun, but is barely noticeable

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Senescence

- “Genetically influenced declines in the functioning of organs and systems that are universal in all members of our species” (Berk, 2010, p.339)
- Begins in early adulthood and gathers pace across the rest of the lifespan
- Primary ageing
- Secondary ageing – effects of health compromising behaviours, illness, environmental influences

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Cardiovascular and Respiratory Changes

- Heart
 - Beginnings of decline
 - few resting changes, lower performance under stress
- Lungs
 - Maximum vital capacity declines after age 25.
 - Stiffness of lungs makes breathing harder with age.

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Sensory system changes

- Sight
 - Visual acuity peaks at about 30, then slowly become farsighted
- Hearing
 - Peaks at about 20, then very gradually declines
 - Vulnerability to workplace damage to hearing increases

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Motor Performance



- Athletic skills peak between ages 20 and 35.
 - decline gradually until sixties or seventies, then faster
- Continued training slows loss.
 - keep more vital capacity, muscle, response speed

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Reproductive Capacity

- Parenthood in 20s often seen as biologically ideal
- Trend toward delaying childbirth
 - Fertility peaks during 20s, begins to decline gradually from 30, more rapidly after 35.
 - Men show a gradual decrease in fertility.



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Health compromising behaviour

- One in eight (12.6%) past-year drinkers consumed more than the recommended guidelines more than once a week (Ministry of Health, 2009).
- Young adults are over represented among drug users
 - Links to mental health issues for some
 - Dunedin Longitudinal Study suggests predisposition to schizophrenia may be activated by cannabis use in adolescence and early adulthood
- Genotype/phenotype

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Obesity

Causes

- Heredity
- Environmental pressures
- Declining physical activity
- New Zealand Health Survey 2015/6
 - Almost one in three adults (aged 15 years and over) were obese (32%)
 - further 35% of adults were overweight but not obese

Consequences

- Health impacts on
 - blood pressure, heart disease
 - diabetes
 - liver, gallbladder
- Social discrimination
 - careers

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- Tasks of adulthood
 - Establishing an occupation
 - Establishing an independent household
 - Establishing intimate relationships

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Neugarten's theory

- The Social clock

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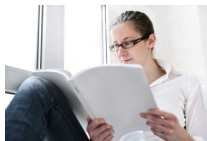
Cognitive Development in adulthood

- **Fluid intelligence**
 - Information processing ability
 - Speed of processing
 - Capacity of working memory
 - At its peak in the 20s, but a gradual decline begins
- **Crystallised intelligence**
 - Acquired and accumulated knowledge and skills
 - Increases steadily in adulthood

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Theories of cognitive development in adulthood

- **Beyond Piaget:** postformal thought
- **Perry:** contextual relativism
- **Labouvie-Vief:**
 - intersystemic thought
 - autonomous thought
- **Schaie:**
 - Life-span model of cognitive development



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Postformal thought

- Many adults use the abstract thought and hypothetico-deductive reasoning of Piaget's formal operational stage
- Theorists increasingly have looked at what changes with adulthood.
- Postformal thought comes with experience and is more pragmatic, accepting contradiction and the constraints of reality

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Postformal thought

- In adulthood
 - Knowledge is relative and not absolute
 - Uncertainty and variation are accepted
 - A coherent viewpoint can be synthesised from contradiction and ambiguity
 - There is less focus on acquiring than on using and applying knowledge
 - Logic and emotion, objectivity and subjectivity, rationality and intuition are integrated



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Contextual relativism- Perry

1. Basic dualism
 - Right/wrong, good/bad
2. Multiplicity
 - No absolute truth, multiple truths
3. Contextual relativism
 - Truth is relative, meaning is dependent on context

Challenges, opportunities to reflect, and peers all contribute to development

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Pragmatic Thought – Labouvie-Vief

- Adulthood brings the chance to use logic to solve real-world problems.
- 2 modes of thought – abstract and emotional
 - Formal mode – objective
 - Internalised mode – intuitive, subjective
- Intrasystemic thought
- Intersystemic thought
- Autonomous thought

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Schaie's stages of Lifespan cognitive development	
Acquisitive	• Childhood and adolescence • Knowledge acquisition
Achieving	• Early adulthood • Adapt cognitive skills to achieve long-term goals (eg. marriage, career)
Responsibility	• Middle adulthood • Cognition devoted to meeting responsibilities • Executive stage – most complex
Reintegrative	• Late adulthood • Reexamine interests, attitudes, values • Creating a legacy

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Work – career development

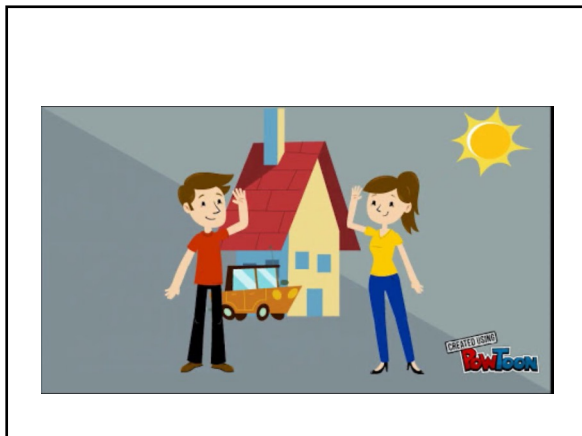
- Early adulthood period of commitment and beginnings of expertise
- Creativity high in early adulthood
- High levels of female participation in the workforce
 - more likely to experience extended periods out of the workforce, often with an impact on career progression and remuneration
 - Pay disparity, occupational segregation

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Socioemotional Development

- **Emerging adulthood**
 - exploring education, work, values, relationships
 - extended psychological moratorium
 - increasing commitment
 - attitudes and values broaden
 - cycle between making and evaluating commitments (MAMA)

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How does contemporary early adulthood differ from early adulthood 20 years ago?

- Or 100 years ago
- How does your early adulthood differ from your parent's experience in early adulthood?

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Emerging Adulthood in context

- Rapid cultural change offers new challenges.
 - Entry-level jobs require more education.
 - delays in financial independence
 - delays in career commitment
- In developing nations, only for privileged
- Unknown in traditional, rural-based nations

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Theories of psychosocial development in adulthood

- Normative crisis models

- Internal influence within social context
- Biology and social expectations
- Erikson, Levinson

- Stability and change

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Childhood Attachment and Adult Romantic Relationships

Attachment History	Working Model	Adult Relationships
Secure	comfortable with intimacy; unafraid of abandonment	trust, happiness, friendship
Avoidant	stress independence, mistrust, anxiety about closeness	jealousy, emotional distance, little physical pleasure, unrealistic beliefs
Resistant	seek quick love, complete merging	jealousy, desperation, emotional highs and lows

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Erikson's Theory: Intimacy versus Isolation

All the stages in the epigenetic sequence are influenced by resolutions of previous stages

- The **Intimacy stage** is particularly dependent on a positive resolution of the Identity stage
- **Identity, intimacy, generativity** are continued threads in all the adult stages
- Psychosocial crisis – new inner needs and matched social expectations

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Intimacy

- Commitments to personal goals prepares for commitment to significant relationships
- Fidelity can be seen as the forerunner for love
- Intimacy involves long lasting commitment to an intimate partner
 - Redefinition of identity in the context of the relationship
 - Compromise and aligning needs
 - But not a loss, a surrender of the self
- Other forms of intimacy – close friendships, parenting



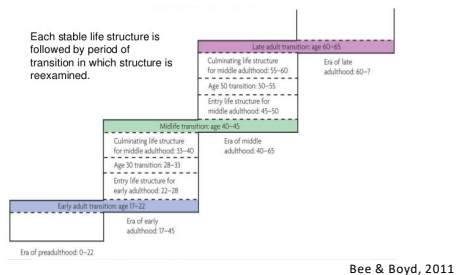
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Isolation

- The negative resolution of the psychosocial crisis involves
 - loneliness, self-absorption
 - stuck in a state of searching
 - negatively associated with fidelity and love
 - difficulty with commitment

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Levinson's seasons of adult lives



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Seasons of life

- Normative crisis model
- Originally, only seasons of men's lives
- Used the biographical method, so small sample
- Later replicated with women
- **Life structure** – the underlying pattern
 - Relationships, work, friendships, leisure
- Sequence characterised by eras and transitions



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Levinson's Early Adult Season

- Early adult transition – novice phase
 - Developing a dream, an image of the self
 - Finding a mentor
- Early adulthood life structure
 - Culminating phase
 - **men**: "settling down"
 - **women**: split dreams
- Age-30 transition
 - reevaluate **life structure**
 - often focus on underdeveloped aspects
 - can be time of crisis



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Friendships in Early Adulthood

- Friends usually similar age, sex, SES
- Common interests, experiences, needs
 - add to pleasure of friendship
- Enhance self-esteem, make life more interesting
- Trust, intimacy, and loyalty continue to be important.
- Siblings often friends



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Trends in Marriage

- Marrying later – median age of first marriage 29.9 for men and 28.2 for women (23.5 and 21.2 in 1971)
- Fewer marriages
 - staying single, cohabiting, not remarrying
- In 2012, the general marriage rate was 11.8 per 1,000, less than one-third of the peak of 45.5 per 1,000 recorded in 1971 (Statistics NZ).
- Civil unions a more recent legal relationship
 - includes same-sex partnerships



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Trends in Having Children

- Delay in having first child – in 2012, women aged 30-34 had the highest rates of birth
- In 1962, women aged 20-24 had the highest rate.
- Average of 2.05 births per woman in 2012, down from 4.31 in 1961
- 24% of children in NZ live in sole parent families



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Parenting

- Powerful source of adult development
- With young children
 - best parents work together as co-parenting team
 - challenges: few social supports, hard to find child care
- With adolescents
 - brings sharp changes
 - challenges: negotiation of roles, dip in marital satisfaction

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Family Life Cycle

- Early adulthood
 - leaving home, committed relationships
 - Parenthood of young and primary aged children
- Middle adulthood
 - Often parenting adolescents
 - launching children
- Late adulthood
 - retirement
 - grandparenting



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